2021 ▶



- Putting the Tokyo debacle behind her, wins gold in 10m air pistol at Junior World Championships in Lima, the women's team gold in 10m, 25m as well as the gold for 10m air pistol mixed team event



◀ 2023

- Has a muted showing in the 2023 ISSF World Cup series with only a bronze in 25m air pistol in Bhopal
- Wins women's team gold in non-Olympic event 25m pistol, her first Asian Games medal

2024 ▼

- Only athlete from the 21-member Indian shooting team to participate in multiple individual events at 2024 Games. Is also one of the four shooters from the Tokyo squad to secure an Olympic ticket again



- Qualifies for finals in all three events in Paris. Wins two bronzes in 10m air pistol and 10m air pistol mixed team events, misses spot on podium in 25m by a whisker
- Is flagbearer for closing ceremony alongside P.R. Sreejesh



"MANU KNOWS SHE IS ANSWERABLE ONLY TO HERSELF, IT HAS NEVER BEEN ABOUT THE COACH, TRAINERS OR OTHERS. IF SHE NEEDS TO DO IT, SHE'LL DO IT, HOWEVER TIRED SHE IS"

— ANJUM MOUDGIL
Rifle shooter

BURYING THE GHOSTS OF TOKYO

"Manu knows she is answerable only to herself, it has never been about the coach, trainers or others. If she needs to do something, she will do it, no matter how tired she is," says rifle shooter Anjum Moudgil, who has seen Manu transition from the junior to the senior team and negotiate the ups and downs along the way. With Rana back as her guide, Manu picked up the diary again and adhered to a schedule. It meant waking up as early as 5 am, doing yoga and meditation, going to the range for practice, then for physiotherapy, rehab sessions for her scapula and elbow, working out in the gym and taking out time for meditation again, before calling it a day.

To prepare for Paris, Manu trained at the ranges in Dehradun, Bhopal, New Delhi and, closer to the Olympics, in Luxembourg and France. The National Rifle Association of India, the body that runs shooting in the country, made an exception for Manu, allowing her to skip the World Cup in Munich in May and instead facilitating a range for her to practise there.

Relieved also of the burden of being the favourite, Manu flourished in Paris. Those watching her at the National Shooting Centre in Châteauroux saw a far more composed and confident athlete. Abhinav Bindra, 2008 Olympic champion, noted how Manu didn't smile when she qualified for the finals of 10m air pistol, demonstrating her resolve to not rest easy till she won. Looking as ice-cool as an assassin with one hand in the pocket and a blinder shielding one eye, Manu was all business as she breezed through the qualifications and made it to the finals of all three events. "There are no longer any regrets about all the losses," Manu told India Today TV after she won India its first medal in Paris. "My heart is clear. I have lots more to accomplish." As the spotlight turned on her, she delivered another medal with Sarabjot Singh in the 10m air pistol mixed team event. Only now did they allow themselves some laughs. "*Match ke baad ek doosre ki laat kheench rahe thhe* [we were pulling each other's leg]," says Singh.

What changed? Confidence and experience, Manu would say later. The confidence she attributes to Rana who, she says, made things so rigorous in training that she only had to execute all that she had learnt for the matches. Experience teaches one a lot in life, she says, and it showed in Paris. If in Tokyo, she was scared of falling short of meeting people's expectations, in Paris, she did not let that affect her.

THE GYM JUNKIE

Outside the shooting ranges, Manu is like any other Gen Z kid who likes to shop for clothes and accessories, or listens to music [pop, Punjabi and Haryanvi pop, Hindi film songs]. Her screen time, though, is still limited, to retain her sight and focus, essential for shooting. Downtime for Manu means going for drives or watching a film. "Sometimes we plan to make a reel and we always fail to do it," says Manu's friend Anshika, 25. While there's no diehard crush, both twentysomethings agree that Aditya Roy Kapoor is easy on the eye. Diligent about her diet, Manu prefers "*ghar ka khaana*" over meals outside.

Manu is also a workout junkie who savours the time she